

## Assessing Film as An Instrument of Peace and Conflict Resolution

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### ABSTRACT

*This study examines the role of film in peacebuilding and conflict resolution, using "Black November" and "Half of a Yellow Sun" as case studies. Through a critical analysis of these works, this study explores how film can be used to promote empathy, understanding, and social change in the context of conflict and post-conflict societies. The study highlights the potential of film to challenge dominant narratives, promote nuanced understandings of conflict, and foster a culture of peace. By examining the ways in which film represents conflict and peacebuilding, this study aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of the role of media in shaping cultural narratives and promoting social change. The findings of this study have implications for the use of film as a tool for peacebuilding and conflict resolution, and highlight the need for further research in this area.*

Keywords: *Conflict, Peacebuilding, Resolution*

### Introduction

In a world where conflicts and violence continue to plague societies, causing immense human suffering and undermining global stability, the need for innovative and creative approaches to promoting peace and resolving conflicts has never been more pressing. Traditional approaches to conflict resolution, such as diplomacy and negotiation, are often insufficient to address the complex and deeply ingrained issues that fuel conflicts. As a result, there is a growing recognition of the need to explore new and complementary approaches to conflict resolution that can help to build sustainable peace and promote social cohesion. One such approach is the use of film as an instrument of peace and conflict resolution.

### Research Problem

Despite the potential of film to promote peace and resolve conflicts, its effectiveness as a tool for conflict resolution remains understudied. While film

has been used in various contexts to promote peace and understanding, there is a lack of systematic research on its impact on conflict dynamics and outcomes. As a result, there is a need to assess the potential of film as a tool for conflict resolution and to explore its limitations and challenges. This study aims to address this research gap by investigating the role of film in promoting peace and resolving conflicts.

### **Research Aims**

This study aims to assess the potential of film as an instrument of peace and conflict resolution. Specifically, the study seeks to examine the ways in which film can be used to promote peace and resolve conflicts, investigate the impact of film on conflict dynamics and outcomes, and identify the key factors that influence the effectiveness of film as a tool for conflict resolution. By exploring these issues, the study aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of the role of film in conflict resolution and to inform the development of more effective conflict resolution strategies that incorporate film and other creative approaches.

### **Research Questions**

This study is guided by three research questions. Firstly, how can film be used to promote peace and resolve conflicts in different contexts? Secondly, what are the key mechanisms by which film influences conflict dynamics and outcomes? Thirdly, what are the challenges and limitations of using film as a tool for conflict resolution? By answering these questions, the study aims to provide insights into the potential of film as a tool for conflict resolution and to identify best practices for using film in conflict resolution initiatives.

### **Significance**

This study is significant because it has the potential to contribute to a deeper understanding of the role of film in promoting peace and resolving conflicts. The findings of this study can inform the development of more effective conflict resolution strategies that incorporate film and other creative approaches. Additionally, the study can contribute to a growing body of research on the use of arts and media for conflict resolution and peacebuilding. By exploring the potential of film as a tool for conflict resolution, this study can help to promote a more nuanced understanding of the complex relationships between media, conflict, and peace.

## **Theoretical Framework**

### **Theory of Aggression**

The following debate for conflict resolution has been inferred with the theory of aggression in the following order.

1. Against Convention: - this convention is to fight against conservation, stagnation, bribery, land monopoly, fraudulent acquisition and arrogant display of wealth. This assertion and proposition was made by Edwin, and Jason Tomaric (2012:23) stating that “conflict resolution can only take place when the parties involved express transparent and honest dialogue and understanding during and after the conflict”.
2. Against Ethnicity: - This supports any form of discrimination based on ethnic affiliation. Lack of consensus among relevant stakeholders in the Nigerian contract on fundamental values and structural arrangements of the Nigerian State has been identified as a source of conflict in Nigeria. Only when all relevant stake-holders are given the opportunity to participate, without preconditions, in deciding on the fundamental values to be pursued by the Nigerian state, institutional arrangements for giving effect to these values, for identifying violations and enforcing conformity with accepted rules, extent of the public domain over the private domain and other critical issues, conflict will remain an endemic feature of the Nigerian system this is developed theoretical insights into the nature and sources of conflict and how conflicts can be resolved through peaceful methods to effectuate durable settlements.

The theory deals with insight into the beneficial consequences of aggressors that factors like the nature of the dispute and the goals each party aims at are pivotal in determining the kind of orientation a party would bring to the negotiating table in its attempt to solve the conflict. This theory brings in the individualist thoughts and disposition towards another and hence could lead to an atmosphere of mistrust and eventually lead to un-mutually beneficial options for settlement. On the other hand, it is a highly competitive approach that leads to win-lose outcomes. This approach is inclined to intensifying animosity and distrust between parties and is generally considered destructive. Some critics of this approach argue, both cooperation and competition are essential to some extent to effectuate resolution of conflict since negotiating a desirable agreement always includes common and diverse goals. Thus finding a balance between these two approaches is the key to successful negotiation.

### **Theory of Consensus**

The theory of consent by Roger Fisher and William Ury (2011:42-57) state that the theory of consensus is principled on negotiation and advocacy which is based on four principles such as;

- i. Focus on interest rather than position.
- ii. Generate a variety of options before settling on an agreement.
- iii. Insist that the agreement be based on objective criteria.
- iv. Respect each other's views based cultural inclination.

At each stage of the negotiation process, the above principles should be observed. Developing a method for reaching good agreements is central to this model. This model asserts that “separate people from their problem”. However, this could make matters worse if human needs of the people are the problem. Moreover, conflicts between ethnic groups are mostly needs based conflicts since one group feels that its basic needs of identity, security, recognition or equal participation are being neglected. Here human needs model can be more useful than interest based model. An individual or group is denied its fundamental recognition or equal participation within the society, protracted conflict is inevitable. To resolve such conflict, it is essential that consensus be reached and identify subsequently social system take enables all individuals and groups involved. For instance, this model can be useful in the case of different race, belief and culture where there are restraints on freedom and participation of its citizens in socio-political life.

Similarly, this theory, while referring to the interest-based and the human needs proffers solution that satisfy each interests and needs that could be reached through these models. However, if negative attitudes are developed the conflict is not addressed, these could serve to generate further conflicts some time later. Whereas the transformation aims at a fundamental change in attitude and/or behavior of individuals and/or the relationship between two or more disputing parties.

This approach is very well exemplified in resolution to refer to peace building. For building peace destructive or negative communication patterns need to be transformed or replaced by constructive or positive interaction patterns. Consensus theory transforms the disputing parties by empowering them to understand their own situation and needs, as well as encouraging them to recognize the situation and needs of their opponents.

### **Marxist Theory**

On the hand, the Marxist theory as propounded by the philosopher- Karl Max in 1818 is an offshoot of the Marxian explanation of society. Society is divided into

unequal classes: the one is strong, rich and noble and bears the tag of bourgeoisie, who controls the instrumentality of state; while the other is deprived, socially deflated, financially infantile and is called the proletariat. According to Mathieu Dubeau (2020:19) “there is a constant struggle between the two, but he that has the financial muscle controls both the state and the poor, and that is the structure of society”. Thus, the Marxist stand is that the state is itself a product of the irreconcilability of class antagonisms.

The state is therefore structured to be in a perpetual state of conflict. The rich controls the state as well as means of production. The rich thus grows wealthier at the expense of the poor, who lives at his mercy and is implicitly embittered by the development. The central argument of Marxism is thus that capitalism is at the heart of the state, and that same capitalism is exploitative and oppressive and has been responsible for the polarization of the society (and state) into two incompatible classes. Marxism theory looked into the nature of man and his environment with a critical understanding of the poor control and equilibrium distribution of resources in the society. One of the problems that has affected the peace building process is the lack of use of the media to promote equality and justice in the society. However, the ratio to which media has been used to control conflict has been very low and consequently has not been able to build peace in the society.

### **Application to Film and Conflict Resolution**

The study applies aggression and Marxist theories to understand how film can be used to promote peacebuilding and conflict resolution. By analyzing film narratives and representations, the study aims to identify how media can be used to challenge dominant ideologies and promote social change. The study also aims to explore how film can be used to reduce frustration and aggression by promoting empathy and understanding. However, using film as Advocacy medium cannot be overemphasized since it is a technology that buttresses its messages with visual and audio at best. According to Ekwuazi, Okome and et al (2012:45) “film is medium that brings to bear the stories and adventures of our life both in the past, now and future depending what the director wants to replicate” (45). The assertion is true of the statement made by Ekwuazi, Okome et al that film has the potentials of replicating our life as at the time the director tailors it. That means using film as a medium of Advocacy is not new to many filmmakers and should not be difficult to be used in anyway. Film is a packaged cultural product by virtue of its sheer commercial and dynamic potentials making it a strong force in communicating very good messages that are socio-

political and socio-culturally related. Film is seen as art and as an industry with a strong potency of culture and a commercial commodity for economic development. Ekwuazi points out that “Nigerian filmmakers are charged with the duty of intensifying efforts to explore and exploit their own cultural resources rather than importing the valueless aspects of western culture”. This is so because culture has been described as seeking to inculcate an awareness of history folklore and beliefs and thought system to gain knowledge of the society.

By fostering critical thinking and media literacy among audiences, film can be a powerful tool for promoting peacebuilding and conflict resolution. Ultimately, the study aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of the role of media in shaping cultural narratives and promoting social change.

### **Conceptual Framework: Film and Peace Studies**

The intersection of film and peace studies offers a unique lens through which to explore the complex relationships between media, conflict, and peacebuilding. This conceptual framework recognizes film as a powerful tool for promoting peacebuilding and conflict resolution, with the potential to shape cultural narratives, influence audience attitudes and behaviors, and inspire social change. Film can be a highly effective tool for peacebuilding, promoting empathy, understanding, and tolerance among audiences. According to Onookome Okome (2012:69) “people are psychologically developed when they watch films (media) that are educative. More so, they emulate very fast and build up on their very act they have emulated. Using media as a resolution medium will help the society in terms of conflict management achieved and help their intellectual potential to improve. By depicting the experiences and perspectives of different groups, film can challenge dominant narratives and promote a more nuanced understanding of conflict and its resolution. Film can also educate audiences about conflict and peacebuilding, promoting awareness and knowledge of the complex issues involved. Furthermore, film can inspire social change, encouraging audiences to take action and promoting a culture of peace.

Peace studies provide a critical framework for understanding the complex dynamics of conflict and peacebuilding. By analyzing the root causes and dynamics of conflict, peace studies can inform the development of effective peacebuilding strategies, such as dialogue, negotiation, and mediation. Peace studies also recognize the importance of cultural sensitivity in peacebuilding efforts, taking into account the unique needs and perspectives of different

groups. By promoting a culture of peace and encouraging social change, peace studies can help to create a more just and equitable society.

### **Intersection of Film and Peace Studies**

The intersection of film and peace studies offers a unique opportunity for exploring the complex relationships between media, conflict, and peacebuilding. By examining the ways in which film represents conflict and peacebuilding, we can gain a deeper understanding of the role of media in shaping cultural narratives and influencing audience attitudes and behaviors. Film can reflect the complexities and nuances of conflict, promoting a deeper understanding of its causes and consequences. According to Best and Saidu (2007:21), “media has been a medium that is accepted by the society because of its antecedents as an organ of communication and it is probably one major way of creating a good face for emulating cultures of diverse kinds”. Film can also be used to promote peacebuilding and conflict resolution, challenging dominant narratives and promoting empathy and understanding. Several key concepts are central to this conceptual framework, including peacebuilding, conflict resolution, and cultural peacebuilding. Peacebuilding refers to efforts to promote peace and resolve conflicts, including dialogue, negotiation, and mediation. Conflict resolution refers to the process of resolving conflicts through peaceful means, such as negotiation and mediation. Cultural peacebuilding recognizes the importance of cultural sensitivity in peacebuilding efforts, taking into account the unique needs and perspectives of different groups.

### **Theoretical Perspectives**

According to Ekwuazi (1992:56) This conceptual framework draws on several theoretical perspectives, including critical peace studies and narrative peacebuilding. Critical peace studies offer a critical approach to peace studies, highlighting the importance of power dynamics and cultural sensitivity in peacebuilding efforts. Narrative peacebuilding recognizes the power of narrative and storytelling in promoting peacebuilding and conflict resolution. According to Ferdinand Laves (2002:61) “conflict is a thing that brings misconception and misunderstanding between two parties or more, therefore, crises can be tailored towards achieving stupidity or discipline”. By examining the ways in which film narratives shape our understanding of conflict and peacebuilding, we can gain a deeper understanding of the role of media in promoting social change. Overall, this conceptual framework provides a

foundation for understanding the intersection of film and peace studies, highlighting the potential of film to promote peacebuilding and conflict resolution. By examining the complex relationships between media, conflict, and peacebuilding, we can gain a deeper understanding of the role of film in shaping cultural narratives and promoting social change.

### **Research Design**

The research design is a qualitative approach that deals with exploratory and seeks to explain 'how' and 'why' a particular phenomenon, or behavior, operates as it does in a particular context.

Interview is another method best for researching many of the why and how questions of human experience it is a method that helps one to gather firsthand information by explanations and case studied; any more general conclusions are considered tentative propositions. A popular method of qualitative research is the case study, which examines in depth 'purposive samples to better understand a phenomenon. The case study method exemplifies the qualitative researchers' preference for depth, detail and context often working with smaller and more focused samples compared with the large samples of primary interest to statistical researchers seeking general laws.

### **Sampling Techniques**

The combination of these sampling techniques will help ensure a well-rounded and representative sample that can provide valuable insights into the impact of community organizing projects.

- i. Stratified Sampling: this sampling method will ensure appropriate and concise information gathering from relevant people without diversifying interest.

### **Sample Size:**

The sample size will be determined based on the principle of saturation, meaning that data collection will continue until no new information or themes emerge from the interviews, and content analysis of the two films Jeta Amata's *Black November* and Biyi Bandele's *Half of a Yellow Sun*. This approach ensures that the sample size is sufficient to address the research questions comprehensively.

### **Methods of Data Collection**

The method of data analysis for this study will involve a systematic and comprehensive approach to make sense of both the qualitative and interview of

relevant stakeholders in the industry who are key players. Given the mixed-methods research design, which combines qualitative and interview, data gathering will become highly analytical and inferential.

**Qualitative Data Analysis:**

- i. Content Analysis: Qualitative data obtained from films. The films are Jeta Amata's *Black November* and Biyi Bandele's *Half of A Yellow Sun*. This involves identifying key themes, patterns, and categories within the textual data.

**Interview Data Analysis:**

This involves stakeholders who data will collected through simple interview. This will provide a clear overview of the theme characteristics of the sample and key variables. The interpretation of findings will involve drawing conclusions based on the analysis and relating them to the research objectives and theoretical framework.

**Technique for Data Analysis**

The data collected in this study will have a simultaneously distribution and analysis through interviews and content analysis of the two films using conceptual and contextual techniques. This combined approach ensures that the research is in-depth, allowing for a thorough examination of the phenomenon under investigation. To enhance the rigor of the study, the findings will be buttressed using some scholarly citations.

Two-Methods Approach: The use of a mixed-methods approach allows for a comprehensive exploration of the impact of assessing film as an instrument of conflict resolution and peacebuilding in the society. This approach combines both qualitative and interviews, enabling a deeper understanding of the research questions. The mixed-methods approach, combining qualitative and interview methods, will address the research questions and aim and objective of this study. It allows for a comprehensive exploration of the impact of the study while ensuring precision and decision making by the researcher.

**Synopsis of Black November and Half of a Yellow Sun**

**Black November**

"Black November" is a gripping movie that tells the story of Ebiere, a young

woman who becomes the face of a revolution in the Niger Delta after her family is killed in a gas leak explosion. The movie explores the themes of struggle, resistance, and the fight for human rights, as Ebieri leads a group of people in a fight against their government and a multinational oil corporation. The corporation is accused of exploiting the region's resources while neglecting the needs of the local population, leading to widespread poverty, pollution, and violence. As Ebieri's fight for justice gains momentum, she becomes a symbol of hope for her community, inspiring others to join the movement.

The movie sheds light on the challenges faced by the people of the Niger Delta, including poverty, pollution, and violence, and highlights the importance of standing up against injustice. Through its powerful performances and gripping storyline, "Black November" raises awareness about the struggles of the Niger Delta and the need for change. The movie also explores the complexities of the oil industry's impact on local communities and the role of government in addressing these issues.

### **Half of a Yellow Sun**

"Half of a Yellow Sun" is a novel set during the Nigerian Civil War, also known as the Biafran War, which took place from 1967 to 1970. The story revolves around three main characters: Ugwu, a young boy from a rural village who becomes a houseboy for a university professor; Olanna, the professor's partner, who leaves her privileged life in Lagos to be with him; and Kainene, Olanna's twin sister, who runs a refugee camp during the war. Through their stories, the novel explores themes of love, identity, colonialism, and the horrors of war.

The novel sheds light on the human cost of war, including the impact on civilians, the destruction of communities, and the loss of loved ones. The characters' experiences are marked by trauma, loss, and resilience, as they navigate the complexities of war and its aftermath. The novel also explores the complexities of identity, including national, ethnic, and personal identity, and how these identities shape the characters' experiences and perspectives.

The novel is a powerful exploration of the Biafran War and its impact on the people of Nigeria. Through its vivid characters and storytelling, "Half of a Yellow Sun" raises awareness about the importance of understanding and empathy in the face of conflict and adversity. The novel highlights the need for nuanced and thoughtful approaches to addressing the complexities of war and its aftermath.

### **Key Themes**

Both "Black November" and "Half of a Yellow Sun" explore key themes that are relevant to the experiences of the people of Nigeria. These themes include the struggle for justice, the impact of conflict on civilians, and the importance of identity and community. The works highlight the need for awareness, empathy, and understanding in addressing the complexities of conflict and adversity.

Overall, both "Black November" and "Half of a Yellow Sun" are powerful works that shed light on the human cost of conflict and the importance of standing up against injustice. Through their stories, the works raise awareness about the struggles of the Niger Delta and the Biafran War, and highlight the need for nuanced and thoughtful approaches to addressing the complexities of war and its aftermath.

### **Summary of Interviews Conducted**

The findings of the study show that group development is identified in terms of orientation for the task and structuring conflict resolution and peacebuilding. From the data analyzed it shows that it supported the findings. For example, the interviews conducted identified subjective characteristics of conflict and filmmaking from diaries to societal infusion. In particular, the study found that storming was marked by concern, conflict, confrontation and criticism, and that these characteristics were major attributes of the study. Such empirical investigations of the findings appear to show that occurrence of conflict reaches a peak at an early stage in group development, after which the study gains cohesion, and the level of conflict study grasped with a sequence of thematic identification. Hence, the findings relate conflict not only to lack of cohesiveness, but also implies that both are tied in with the maturity of the group. What the findings does not indicate is whether this only applies to a particular type of conflict, or even just to a particular reaction to conflict. The findings have its origins in the interaction process analysis developed the empirical studies which support it only measure the social responses of interviewees. Hence, it is possible that what the findings is really showing is that the group learns to deal with conflict and suppress emotional responses. If this is the case, then, the findings say very much about the underlying level of conflict throughout study. The study finds out that the methodological and conceptual problems concludes that the conflict has a negative effect on the society. On the other hand, the study points out that there are likely to be aspects to develop to support the notion in general than there is to support. The

study suggests that it is more useful to identify significant differences and similarities in conflict for the sake of prioritizing transformation. The finding is concerned with disorderliness, discontinuous change results in a transformation of attitudes on local issues and describes how members of the society unconsciously accept covert roles to dramatize the central conflicts of the with negative attributes (scapegoat) and positive attributes (charismatic prophet). The process by which these roles are accepted and integrated is known as reparation. From our discussions so far, it showed that conflict is not necessarily dysfunctional. The assertions in consider how conflict can be productive. The idea of productive conflict is not new it is creativity, innovation, and development to some extent.

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